

What are the risk factors?

Last revised in March 2025

Risk factors for type 2 diabetes include:

- Obesity and inactivity
 - People who are overweight or obese (especially with central obesity) and/or have inactive lifestyles are at increased risk for developing type 2 diabetes, as overeating and inactivity can exacerbate insulin resistance. Obesity accounts for 80–85% of the overall risk for developing type 2 diabetes [[Diabetes UK, 2019a \(/topics/diabetes-type-2/references/\)](#)]. See the CKS topic on [Obesity \(/topics/obesity/\)](#) for more information.
- Family history
 - People with a family history of diabetes are 2–6 times more likely to have diabetes than people without a family history. The risk of developing type 2 diabetes is about 15% if one parent has type 2 diabetes, and 75% if both parents have type 2 diabetes [[Diabetes UK, 2020 \(/topics/diabetes-type-2/references/\)](#)].
- Ethnicity
 - People of Asian, African, and Afro-Caribbean ethnicity are 2–4 times more likely to develop type 2 diabetes than white people [[Diabetes UK, 2020 \(/topics/diabetes-type-2/references/\)](#)].
- History of gestational diabetes
 - Women with a history of gestational diabetes have a seven-fold increased risk for developing type 2 diabetes later in life. Children born to mothers with gestational diabetes have a six-fold increased risk for developing type 2 diabetes.
- Diet
 - A low-fibre, high glycaemic index (GI) diet may increase the risk of being overweight or obese. High-GI foods contain carbohydrates that are broken down quickly and cause a rapid increase in blood glucose levels, such as sugary foods and drinks, white rice, white bread, and potatoes.
- Drug treatments
 - Statins, corticosteroids, and combined treatment with a thiazide diuretic plus a beta-blocker, can increase the risk for developing hyperglycaemia and type 2 diabetes.
- Polycystic ovary syndrome
 - This increases the risk of non-diabetic hyperglycaemia and type 2 diabetes. See the CKS topic on [Polycystic ovary syndrome \(/topics/polycystic-ovary-syndrome/\)](#) for more information.
- Metabolic syndrome
 - Insulin resistance is commonly associated with the metabolic syndrome, defined as a combination of raised blood pressure, dyslipidaemia, fatty liver disease, central obesity, and a tendency to develop thrombosis. See the CKS topics on [Hypertension \(/topics/hypertension/\)](#), [Lipid modification – CVD prevention \(/topics/lipid-modification-cvd-prevention/\)](#), [Non-alcoholic fatty liver disease \(NAFLD\) \(/topics/non-alcoholic-fatty-liver-disease-naflD/\)](#), and [Obesity \(/topics/obesity/\)](#) for more information.
- Low birth weight for gestational age

- There is some evidence that preterm birth before 35 weeks of gestation is associated with an increased risk for type 2 diabetes developing in adult life [[Kajantie et al, 2010 \(/topics/diabetes-type-2/references/\)](#)].

[[Candler, 2018a \(/topics/diabetes-type-2/references/\)](#); [Zeitler, 2018 \(/topics/diabetes-type-2/references/\)](#); [Diabetes UK, 2020 \(/topics/diabetes-type-2/references/\)](#); [NICE, 2020a \(/topics/diabetes-type-2/references/\)](#)]

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